



clash between CPI(M) workers, the police and tribals. The incident took place when the body of a CPI(M) zonal committee member, Nandalal Pal, was being brought back to Lalgarh. Pal had allegedly been killed by Maoists the previous day. As his body was being carried by CPI(M) workers along with police, a rally of the People's Committee against Police Atrocities (PCPA) was on at Khas Jangal. "Our men requested the police not to enter the village as we had been boycotting them since

a Maoist tag on the villagers, leading to police excesses and forcing a rebellion. Mahato says, "The area has been neglected by the Government and that has made the tribals wary. Moreover, tribals have been tortured for years by CPI(M) workers and the police have always been on their side."

The chief minister later said in the Assembly that the tribal protests in West Midnapore were being steered by someone who was a "Trinamool worker, and brother of a wanted Maoist leader". The pointed jibe from CPI(M) that Trinamool Congress supremo Mamata Banerjee was supporting Maoists did not deter her. She visited the troubled area on February

(LEFT) TRIBAL WOMEN AT A PROTEST RALLY IN LALGARH; (BELOW) FELLED TREES BLOCKING THE ROADS TO KEEP THE POLICE AWAY



were on their way back to Kolkata after inaugurating the Jindal Steel plant at Salboni. The VIPs had a narrow escape as the bombs planted on the way went off just after their convoy had passed. Since then, the police has been swooping down on tribal-dominated area looking for Maoists and arresting innocent villagers of Lalgarh, one of the worst-hit Naxal areas.

There is widespread violence here and the felled trees that partially block the roads or even the areas where the dug up roads have been hastily repaired a bit to allow movement, are chilling reminders that the tribals of Lalgarh have kept their enemy no. 1—the state police—away.

On February 2, at Khas Jangal, three tribals were shot down in a

THE TRIBAL UNREST ISN'T JUST DUE TO POLICE KILLINGS; IT IS THE RESULT OF PENT-UP RAGE AGAINST THE LEFT GOVERNMENT.

November. But in reply they shot at us and three of our brothers lost their lives. These villagers are scared, especially if they have to face the prospect of being killed," says PCPA leader Chhatradhar Mahato.

The tribal unrest is not just because of the police killings; it is the result of deep-rooted grievances against a Government that has given the area a miss as far as development projects are concerned. But it lost no time on jumping on them and forcing

4 despite road blocks and a bandh and said that it was not the people of the area but the CPI(M) who did not want her to reach out to the tribals and fight for their cause.

PCPA leaders say theirs has been a peaceful agitation and they never retaliated even when boys and young men were picked up at random by police and labelled Maoists. "The tribals are supposed to get 100 days of work from the Government. But hardly anyone gets more than 10 to 15 days,"